A Cross-Register Computational Analysis of Hindi Copula Deletion: Movie Subtitles vs. Literary Fiction

ABSTRACT: We propose a synchronic, corpus-based analysis of zero copula in modern Hindi to investigate the syntactic and stylistic environments that license the omission of the present-tense auxiliary (*hai/hain*). To evaluate this, we will compile and analyze a dataset of approximately 150 sentences drawn from two contrasting registers: informal spoken Hindi (film subtitles) and formal literary Hindi (published fiction). Sentences will be systematically tagged and cross-tabulated by copula realization, predicate type, and polarity. We hypothesize that there is a strong correlation between register and deletion, with the zero copula expected to appear at significantly higher frequencies in casual dialogue than in formal narration. Furthermore, the study aims to test potential structural constraints, proposing that deletion favors equational and negative predicates while remaining highly restricted in locative expressions. Ultimately, this research seeks to benchmark these hypotheses against our collected corpus to provide a quantitative snapshot of how stylistic and syntactic boundaries govern Hindi copula drop.

EXPERIMENTAL METHODOLOGY:

Corpus Compilation: We will construct a small, dataset of approximately 100 to 150 present-tense Hindi sentences sourced from two distinct registers:

- **Informal/Spoken Register:** Sentences will be extracted from publicly available Hindi movie subtitles (e.g., via OpenSubtitles or YouTube) to represent natural, colloquial dialogue.
- **Formal/Literary Register:** Sentences will be extracted from a published Hindi short story (e.g., by Premchand or a contemporary author) to represent standard written narration.

Data Annotation (Tagging): The collected sentences will be compiled into a spreadsheet and manually tagged across several specific parameters to enable computational analysis. The tagging scheme we will record:

- **Register:** Subtitle (spoken) vs. Short Story (literary).
- **Predicate Type:** Equational/Nominal (e.g., Vah mera bhai hai **vs.** Vah mera bhai), Adjectival (e.g., Yeh khana bahut achha hai **vs.** Yeh khana bahut achha), or Locative/Existential (e.g., Maa ghar par hai **vs.** Maa ghar par).
- **Polarity:** Affirmative(e.g.,Vah taiyaar hai vs. Vah taiyaar) vs. Negative (presence of *nahin*).(eg., Vah taiyaar nahin hai vs. Vah taiyaar nahin).
- **Copula Status:** A binary value of 1 (copula *hai/hain* is present) or 0 (copula is deleted).

Computational Analysis: We will process the tagged dataset to generate frequency distributions and cross-tabulations. This will allow us to quantitatively benchmark the rate of copula deletion against our two primary variables (Register and Predicate Type) and determine if the statistical patterns support the proposed structural constraints.